workflows, and take advantage of tools developed by the broader community.

While Cedar is not the only policy language available—and we will explore others in the next chapter—it offers an excellent framework for understanding the essential components of policy. Its core ideas align well with broader concepts in access control, making it easier to apply what you learn here to other systems in the future.

In the following sections, we'll examine how Cedar structures policies and models access requests using the PARC framework, and how its evaluation engine makes decisions.

7.2 Policy structure: effect, scope, and conditions

Cedar policies are structured around three key elements: effect, scope, and conditions. These elements specify what a policy does, when it applies, and under which circumstances. Collectively, they form the foundation of policy logic in Cedar and many other policy languages as well.

This section explains how these elements are expressed in Cedar. We won't go into detailed syntax yet, but we'll introduce each part conceptually so that you can recognize them when we look at real examples later.